

CAREER CONVERSATION

A vague promise motivates nobody, it only postpones the frustration to the next cycle.

How to talk about the future without promising what you cannot.

AND THE CONSEQUENCE

What builds trust is saying what is and is not in your hands.

THE CASCADE

The good intention that becomes a debt.

WHAT YOU SEE

The person asks about the future and you want to keep her.

THE MECHANISM

Out comes a maybe next year that she hears as a yes.

THE CONSEQUENCE

The cycle closes with no promotion, and you lost both things.

A promise that depends on other people is not a commitment. It is a loan against your credibility.

THE FORK

What you are about to say depends on whom?

WHO DECIDES THIS

01

Depends only on you?

you can promise it, with a date

02

Depends on you and someone else?

say you will argue for it, not that it will happen

03

Depends on budget and the calendar year?

state the condition, never the promise

The sentence moves from it will happen to I will argue for it. One word separates trust from debt.

THE METHOD

The Four Boxes.

01 **WHAT I DECIDE**

scope, exposure, projects, the priorities of her week

02 **WHAT I INFLUENCE**

promotion, band, visibility, and I say how I argue for it

03 **WHAT IS NOT MINE**

budget, restructuring, whether the window opens or not

04 **WHAT IS ON YOU**

the capability that opens the next door, here or elsewhere

The whole conversation fits in those four. The problem is saying it all as if it were the first.

WHAT TO ASK, IN ORDER

Four questions to prepare the conversation.

01 • WHAT I
DECIDE

What can I change alone in her week?

that is already a delivery, and it beats a promise

02 • WHAT I
INFLUENCE

Where do I have a voice, and how will I use it?

state the argument, not the outcome

03 • WHAT IS
NOT MINE

What does not depend on anyone here?

saying it early prevents resentment later

04 • WHAT IS ON
YOU

Which capability opens the next door?

with a name, and with how to train it

TWO MODELS

Two conversations about the same future.

THE COMMON MODEL

The promise talk

Talks about title and about when

Mixes what it decides with what it hopes

Ends with everyone excited

The frustration shows up next cycle

THE DESIGNED MODEL

The four boxes talk

Talks about capability and evidence

Separates what it decides from what it argues for

Ends with someone uncomfortable and informed

The trust shows up next cycle

MISTAKE AND CONSEQUENCE

Three common slips.

01 Promising in order to keep someone.

- you buy three months and lose the person angry afterward.

02 Dodging the subject when there is no good news.

- an absent conversation is read as an absent future.

03 Talking only about title, never about capability.

- a title depends on the year, a capability travels with the person.

An uncomfortable truth builds more loyalty than a comfortable promise.

THE CHAIN

The promise out loud test.

01

Before saying it, repeat the sentence to yourself.



02

Ask whether you could deliver it alone, depending on nobody.



03

If the answer is no, swap I promise for I will argue for it.



WHERE LEADERSHIP STEPS IN

Five seconds of silence prevent a year of resentment.

RUN IT THIS WAY NEXT TIME

Three moves before the next conversation.



STEP 01

Write the four boxes before entering the room.

with the real name of what sits in each one



STEP 02

Start with what you decide alone.

delivering something
small today beats
promising something
big



STEP 03

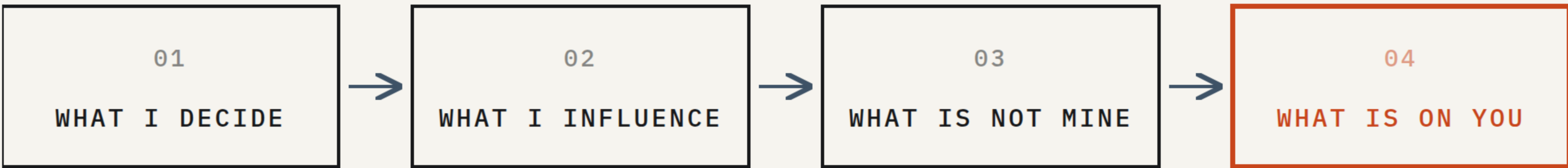
Finish by naming one capability with evidence.

what has to show up, and
how you will both know

If the box of what you decide is empty, the problem is not the conversation. It is your mandate.

THE MODEL THAT STICKS

The Four Boxes, in the order that matters.



A vague promise does not motivate. It only postpones the frustration.

SAVE THIS FOR LATER
before your team's next career conversation.

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